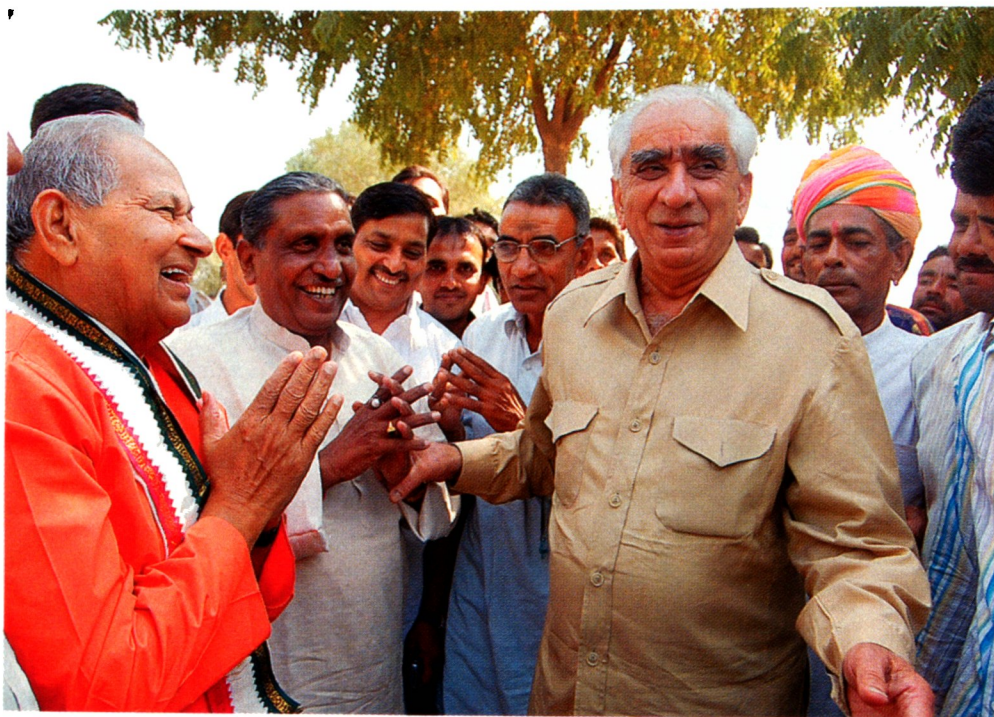




ADDING FUEL TO FIRE: Jaswant Singh (centre) with state BJP rebels

for his loyalty with the post of the state party president and a Rajya Sabha membership despite having lost the Assembly polls twice in succession. Tiwari, a known Shekhawat detractor, was also initially pampered and a few important portfolios like education were bestowed upon him. He is now eyeing the chief minister's seat. To add to Raje's woes, these dissidents have a supporter in former Union finance minister Jaswant Singh, who is upset over Raje ignoring him and his MP son Manvendra Singh. Jaswant recently played host to the rebels in his native village Jassol, sending out a message that he was supporting them in raising their voice against the chief minister.

What has come to the aid of the dissidents is the party's divide with RSS.

Since the Sangh doctrine inculcates a natural protest against non-RSS members, the dissidents have used it to create a wedge by sending signals that Raje loyalists have broken away from the Sangh. Adding to the confusion is RSS's silence over the issue. But the dissident's game boomeranged

strength in attracting people and showcasing her popularity in the state. Her own soft approach to dissidents has kept her from enjoying absolute power despite the support of 123 MLAs as compared to Shekhawat, who lasted a full term with only 90 MLAs. Meghwal recently accused her of minting crores of rupees, at a dinner hosted by party president Rajnath Singh. He got away with this accusation as did Jain, who backed Meghwal and criticised Raje's induction of Gopal Pachherwal, a Scheduled Caste leader, into the party in September.

Raje's reaction to all this has been mild. Instead of cutting Tiwari down to size, she withdrew his powers to transfer teachers only to hand them to another dissident. She relieved social welfare and cooperatives minister Madan Dilwar of one of his portfolios

when he revolted against her. With the state polls a year away and strife within the party in Rajasthan continuing to impede Raje, a timely intervention by the BJP high command seems to be the only way to bring the warring factions together to work collectively for victory in November 2008. ■

Raje has now begun ignoring dissidents and is instead focussing on the state party unit ahead of polls.

relationship souring with Shekhawat, who pushed her into state politics to cut his detractors to size. At least six dissidents—former state party president Lalit Kishore Chaturvedi; former deputy chief minister and state deputy chairman of Economic Policy and Reform Council who enjoys the rank of a cabinet minister, Hari Shankar Bhabhra; education minister Ghan-shyam Tiwari; Shekhawat's son-in-law and industry minister Narpal Singh Rajvi; former Union minister Kailash Meghwal and the party's chief whip Mahavir Prasad Jain—first tried to work against Raje by propping up Mahesh Sharma as state party president. He assumed office much against the wishes of Raje, who had her apprehensions keeping in mind the factions behind him. But Sharma refused to oblige her detractors as Raje gave him enough support and space. Realising that the central high command wanted her to continue as chief minister, they then tried to replace Sharma with their man but she got him renominated. In desperation, they started inciting other ministers to boycott cabinet meetings and openly questioning her decisions.

These are the very men who the chief minister had treated rather well in the beginning of her tenure. Chaturvedi had gone the extra mile five years back to support Raje at the cost of annoying RSS. He was rewarded